of reassurance that the international community recognizes as vital to the coming times. In line with this thinking is a growing realization that Free Trade Agreement (FTA) choices should not be divorced from strategic directions. Precisely because much that India has to build lies ahead of it, we have greater stakes in ensuring the requisite partnerships and accessing the necessary resources.

India is, however, in it not just for itself. For the Global South that has barely come to terms with Covid, the Ukraine conflict has added to their trauma. The 3F (food, fuel and fertilizer) insecurity has been aggravated by trade and tourism disruptions. Concerns have been intensified by the perceived insensitivity of the developed towards their predicament. As homilies on open markets are pronounced while shortages mount, many legitimately fear that their experiences of vaccine inequity will be repeated in other domains.

In this situation, India has to summon its rallying powers in addition to its production capacity. Even against some headwinds, we have championed the cause of the economic security of the South. Setting an example in that respect is itself a powerful message. We stood our ground against considerable odds when it came to Covid, refusing to sacrifice the interests of our citizens. Energy security is a different but not dissimilar fight and what we do has a resonance well beyond.

Let us, therefore, take stock of what we confront. As it is, a world order into its eighth decade had run its course and is ripe for change. This is driven both by the national prospects of major powers as well as the cumulative impact of greater rebalancing and multipolarity. To that is added the complexity of a more interdependent, tech-centric and borderless world, where the concepts of power and influence have acquired new meanings. And this mix now experiences a pandemic that exceeds any in living memory; a conflict that impacts the most complacent continent and beyond; a power vacuum in a sensitive region like Afghanistan and both departures and reaffirmations in a volatile one like West Asia. Some major players have heightened awareness of their predicament while others have made sharp assertions of power. This is really a new era of multiple strategic competitions. As a result, there is truly disorder under the heavens, and it will take all the fortitude and staying power of a civilizational polity like Bharat to tackle it effectively.